

Emergency Escalation Card

Print this. Pin it in Slack. Put it in your VA's hands. A protocol beats panic, every time.

Emergencies happen: burst pipes, power outages, locked-out guests, mice. What matters is how fast and how calmly your system responds.

The Escalation Matrix

A clear decision tree prevents panic and keeps things moving fast.

Tier	Who acts	Examples
\$0-\$50 issues	VA handles without asking	WiFi reset, power reset, small supplies, guest lockout (issue a fresh smart-lock code), basic communication
\$50-\$200 issues	VA calls for approval, then dispatches	Minor repairs, furniture moves, supply runs, quick plumbing fixes
\$200+ issues	VA calls immediately, owner decides	Burst pipes, HVAC failure, roof leak, structural damage, major electrical work
Urgent and guest upset	Immediate owner call	Never handle guest conflict escalation through a VA. Own the conversation.

One note on “calls immediately,” since that phrase worries people. The VA stabilizes the guest first: acknowledge the message, dispatch the standby vendor from the pre-approved list, offer the playbook remedy. You get woken only when a decision can't wait until morning. Spending limits and playbooks keep the midnight call rare, not impossible.

This matrix removes decision fatigue and lets your team act without you.

First Reply to the Guest

Reply quickly even if you don't have the fix yet:

Thanks for flagging this, we're on it. I've messaged our repair team and will update you soon.

Then ask for photos:

Can you send a quick photo so we can get the right person out to fix it?

Photos prevent exaggeration and give your team context.

Standby Contractor List

Build your go-to list before you need it. Find vendors with strong Google reviews before anything breaks. Store the numbers in your phone, your VA's phone, and Slack's pinned messages.

Role	Name	Phone	Pre-approved spend limit	Notes
24/7 plumber			\$	
Electrician			\$	
HVAC tech			\$	
General handyman			\$	
Backup cleaner			\$	
Local contact (neighbor, friend, or real estate agent)			n/a	

- ☐ Numbers saved in owner's phone
- ☐ Numbers saved in VA's phone
- ☐ List pinned in Slack

Smart-Device Early Warning

Use smart devices as your early warning system on a property you may not visit for months.

Device	What it warns you about
Minut noise monitor	Temperature drops before pipes freeze; flags smoking or parties before they become damage (no audio recorded, real-time alerts)
Ring exterior camera	Shows you what's actually happening instead of what you fear is happening; catch parties early, confirm contractors actually showed up
Smart lock (Schlage Encode)	Issue a fresh code for locked-out guests from your phone; keep a backup code for your cleaner and change it quarterly
Smart thermostat	Control temperatures remotely and prevent frozen pipes in winter

The Money Backstop

- ☐ Peace-of-mind fund: set aside \$500–\$1,000 per property for emergencies. Repairs come out of the fund, not out of your cash flow or your sleep.
- ☐ The real backstop is the capex sinking fund: 1–2% of home value a year and at least \$10K liquid per property.

The Six Pieces, Together

- ☐ The go-to list (above, filled in)
- ☐ The Escalation Matrix (pinned)
- ☐ The fast-reply playbook (scripts above)
- ☐ The sensors (devices online)
- ☐ The fund (funded)
- ☐ A cleaner trained to spot trouble (see the Cleaning and Turnover SOP)

Put all six together and an emergency turns into a checklist your team runs.
